

PATHWAYS · READING

What makes a strong CV

A short guide for learners

A CV (curriculum vitae) is a short, written summary of who you are and what you can offer. Its job is narrow but important: to persuade the person reading it, in the little time they give it, that you are worth finding out more about. A strong CV does not list everything you have ever done. It selects the evidence that matters for a particular opportunity and presents it so a busy reader can grasp it quickly.

Show results, not just duties

The most common weakness in a CV is describing tasks instead of achievements.

"Responsible for the shop" tells a reader little; "Ran a small shop alone on weekends, keeping the accounts and serving fifty customers a day" shows what you can actually do. Wherever you can, turn a duty into a result: what changed because you did it, how many, how well.

Your experience is wider than you think

Learners often undersell themselves, leaving off unpaid work, volunteering, family responsibilities, languages and skills built informally. These count. Caring for younger siblings, translating for your family, organising a community event, or fixing things people depend on all demonstrate capability. A reader cannot value experience you do not put on the page.

Structure and honesty

Keep the structure clear and scannable: contact details, a short profile, education, experience, skills, and references. Be concise, and be honest. Conventions differ by country and sector: length, whether to include a photo, and what personal details to add all vary, so check what is expected where you are applying rather than copying a template blindly.

A CV is never finished

Treat your CV as a living document. Tailor it for each opportunity, emphasising the experience that fits, and update it whenever you learn or achieve something new. The version you write today is a foundation, not a final answer.